How to Write API Documentation as a Technical Writer

by Jordan Stanchev

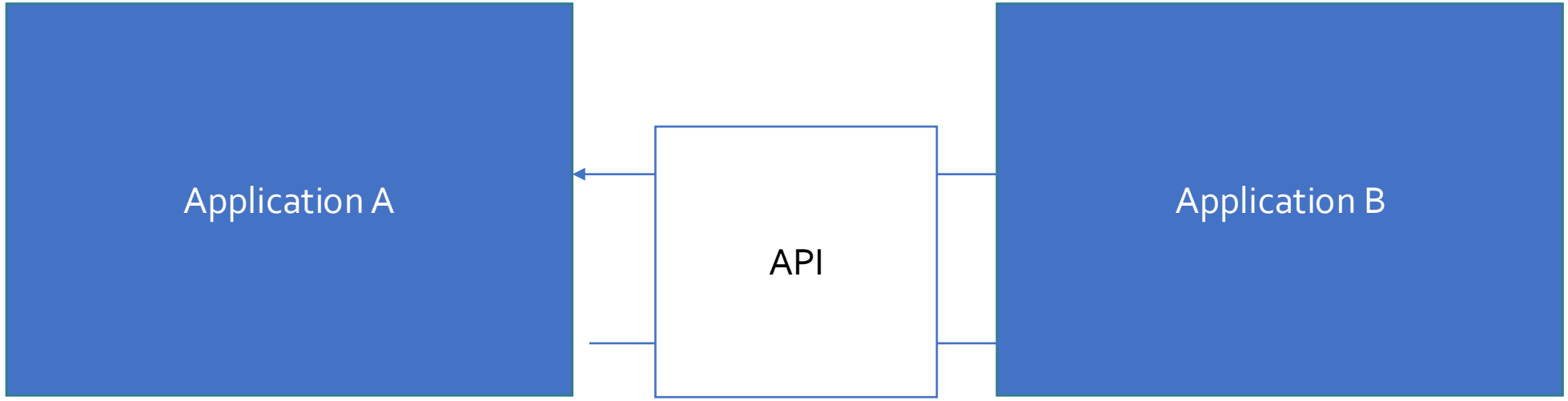
What will you learn?

- ✓ What’s an API and what are the benefits from using APIs?
- ✓ How does an API work?
- ✓ Hands-on to get you started using Open API Swagger UI

What’s an API?

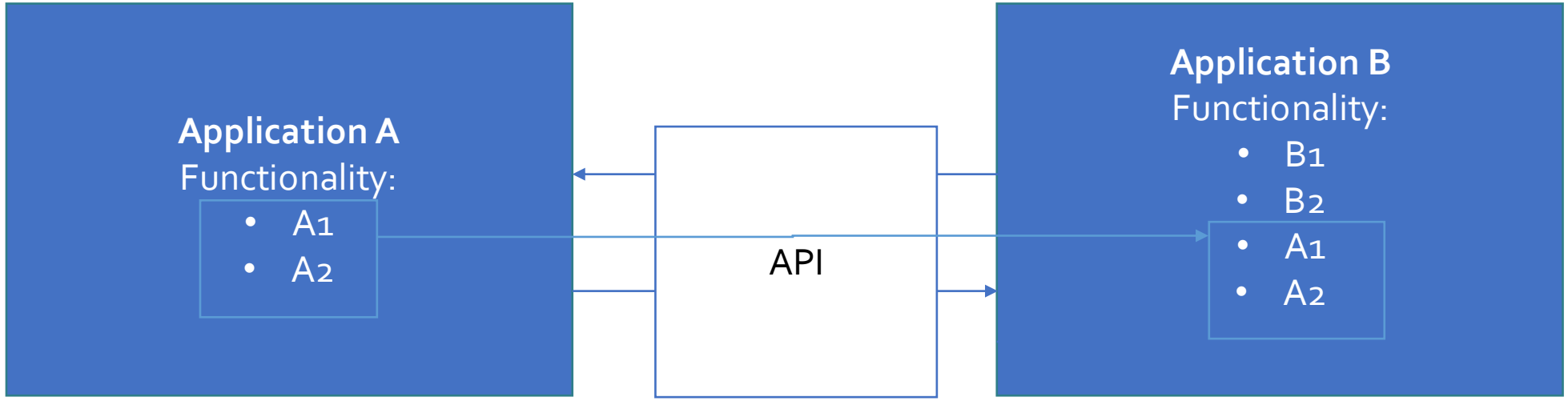
APIs stands for an *application programming interface*.

The API allows two different software application to interact with each other. Using the API these applications can exchange data in a reliable way.



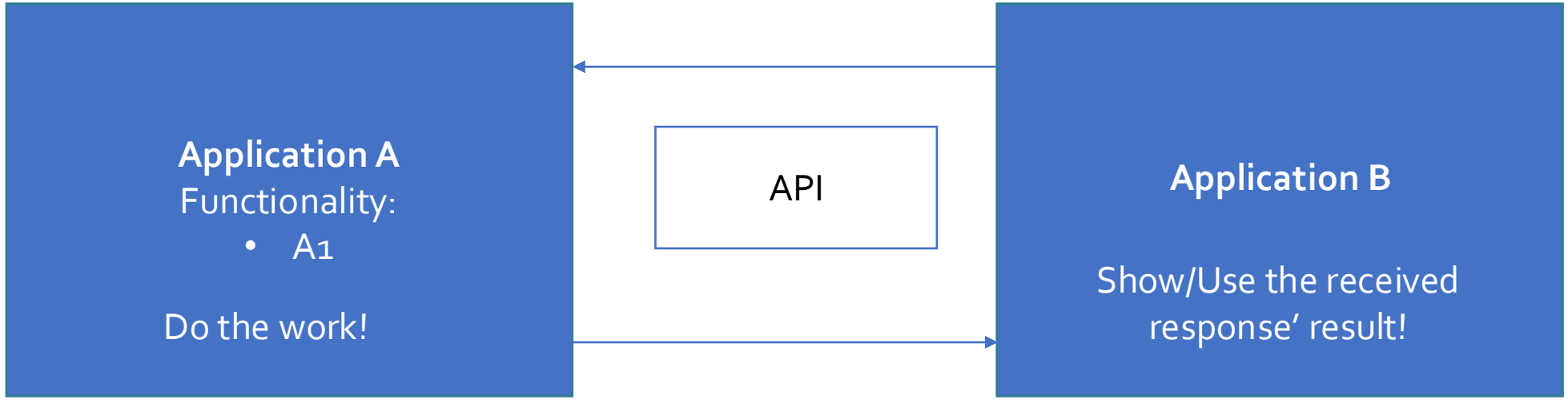
Benefits from Using an API

By using an API, the applications can gain immediate access to software modules and functionality that is already developed by another application. This way you can leverage and re-use existing functionality from another application in the context of your own app, allows you to offer more functionality to your customers.



How Does an API Work?

When using an API, an application first sends a **request** to use the functionality. The receiving application performs all the **work** and, in the end, returns a **response**.



Who Creates the API and the API Documentation? Or Who Does What?

Usually, you must be the developer who created the API to be able to explain how the API works.

Usually, the technical writers are not the developers, but are a part of the team of developers who creates the API.

As a consequence, a technical writer would focus on writing documentation about using the API. But you need the developer who created the API to achieve this goal!

API Documentation - Examples

SAP’s API documentation sample:

https://api.sap.com/

Apple’s API documentation:
https://developer.apple.com/documentation/

Facebook’s API documentation:
https://developers.facebook.com/docs/

Google API documentation:
https://developers.google.com/workspace/products

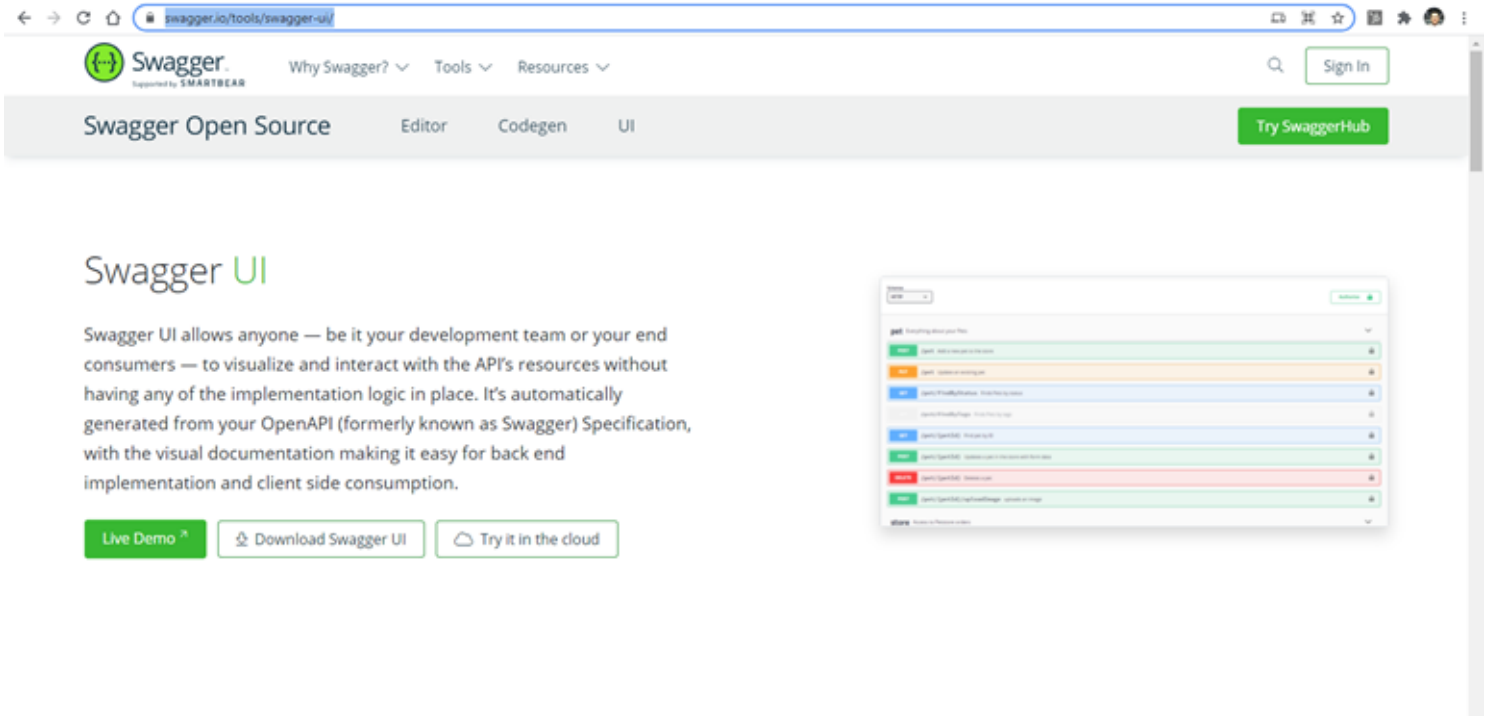
Tools for Writing OpenAPI Documentation

Swagger UI (OpenAPI)

Tool for Automated Generation of API Documentation

Which tools to use to **automatically generate** API documentation?

https://app.swaggerhub.com/apis/JPDocu/JPDocu_sample1/1.0.0



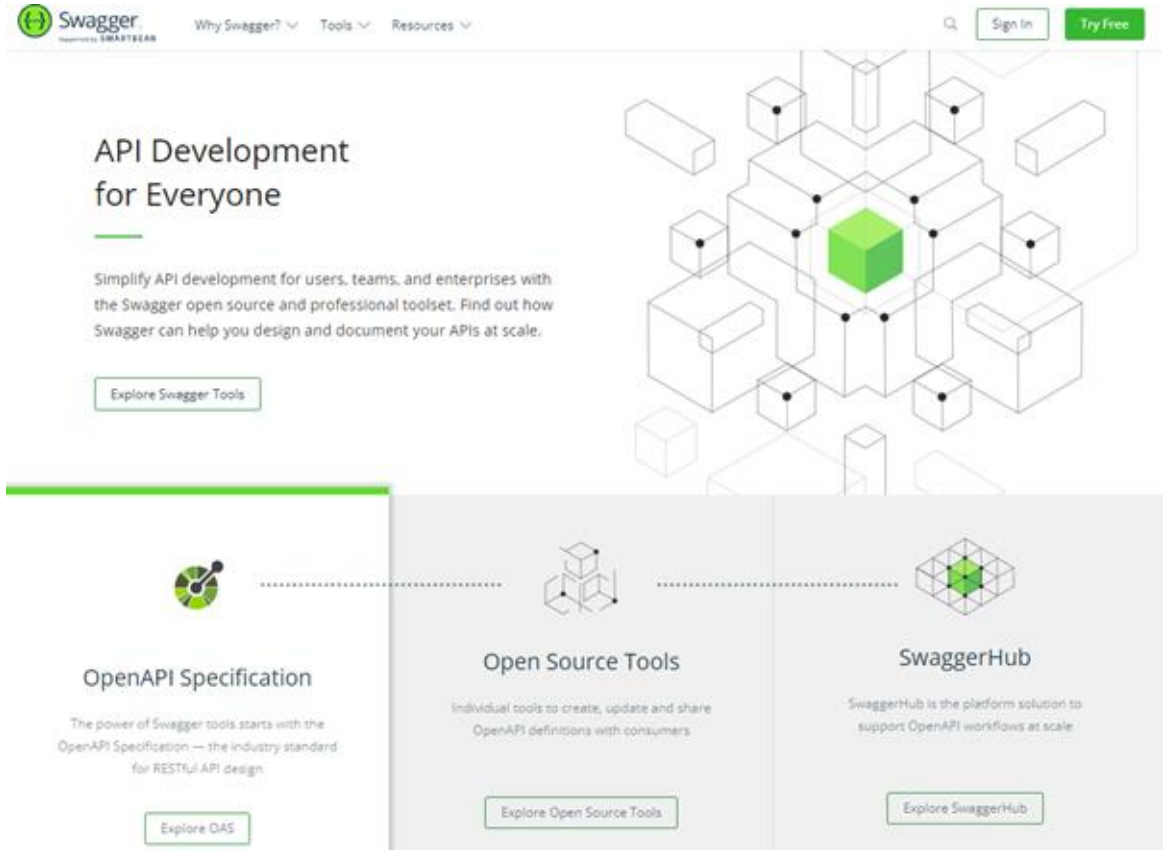
What is Swagger?

https://swagger.io/

An API development platform that brings together capabilities of the open source Swagger framework, as well as additional capabilities that allows you to:

- build,
- document,
- manage,
- and deploy

APIs



Step 1: Create New API

Prerequisites

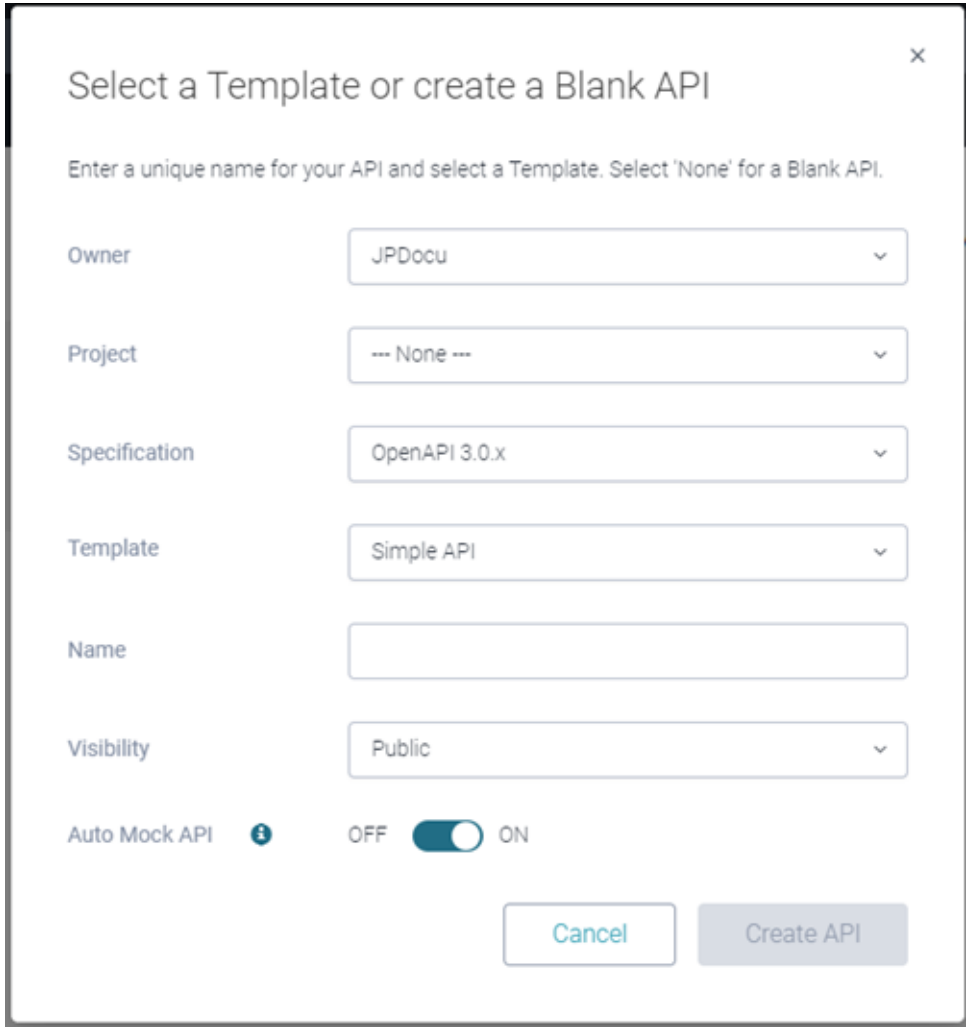
Create your account and log on to the SwaggerHub: https://app.swaggerhub.com/home

Steps

1. Choose *Create New*.
2. Choose *Create New API*.
3. In the dialog that appears, enter your sample API details.
   Note: On the free plan you can only have a visibility: *Public* API.
4. Choose *Create API* button.

Result

Your new API appears in the list of APIs under *My Hub*.



Step 2: Create the API Introductory Page

1. Under *My Hub*, select your newly created API.
2. Click on *Open to Edit* that appears.

   Your API is loaded in the Swagger UI editor tool.

Step 3: Edit the API Info

1. Under *My Hub*, select your newly created API.

2. Click on *Open to Edit* that appears.
Your API is loaded in the Swagger UI editor tool.

3. Enter the API summary information.
Make it clear what is the intended use of the API. This is like a landing page for your API documentation for people who see it for the first time. Make it easy to follow.

Step 4: Edit the API Contacts and Links to Further Documentation

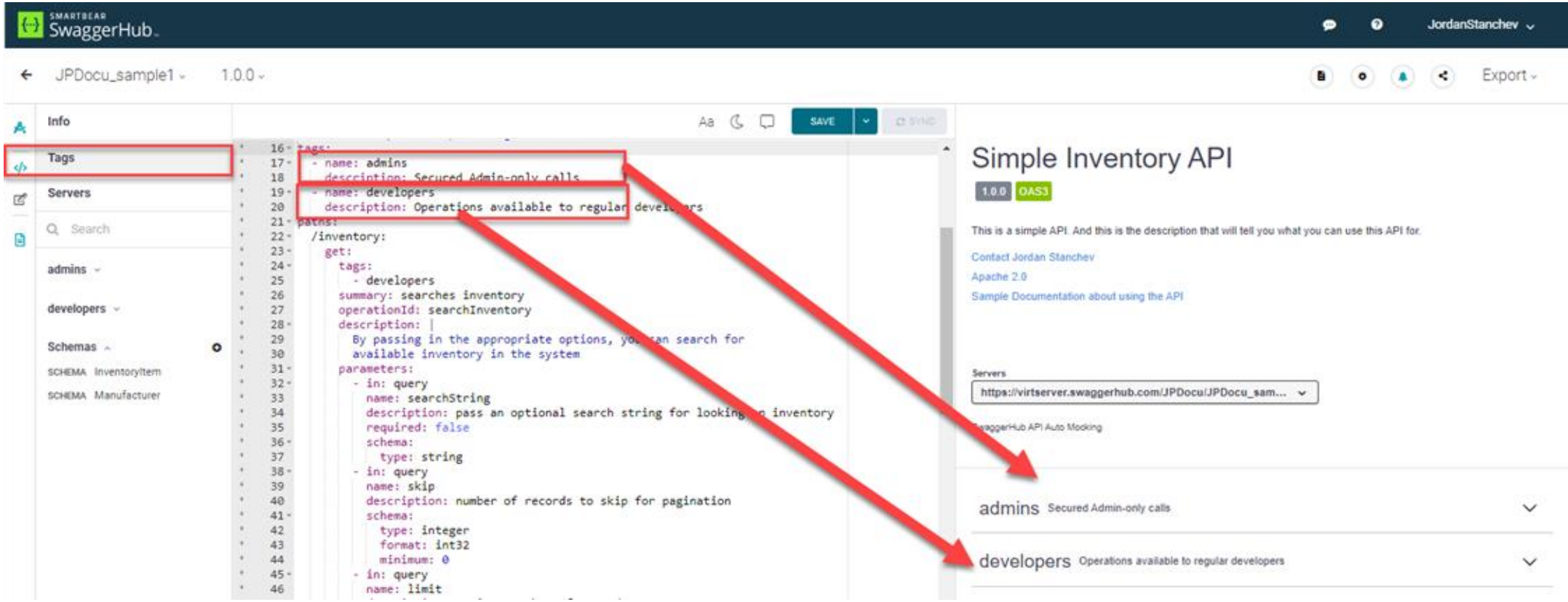
1. Make it clear whom to contact in case of questions about the API.

2. Provide a link to your further documentation – getting started guide, tutorials, end-users guides, etc., that are NOT a part of the API documentation itself.

Remember the documentation framework steps – supply information about the connection and authentication mechanism to connect to the API.

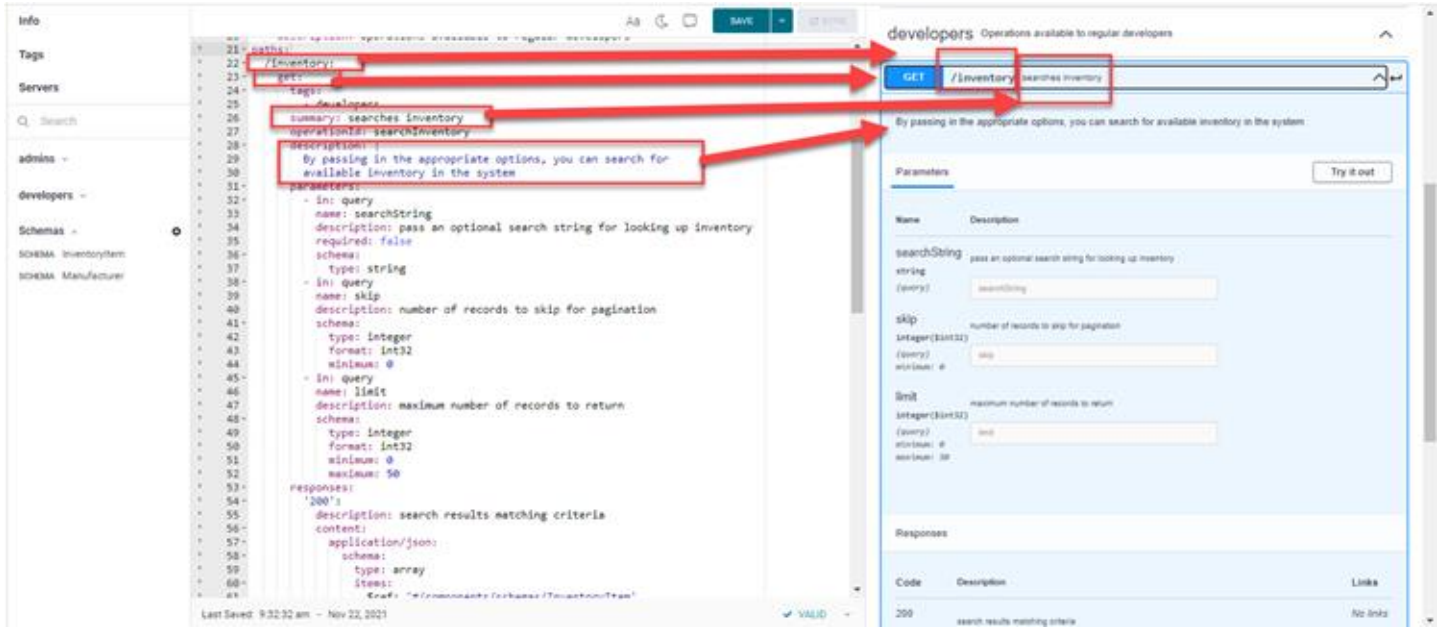
Step 5: Define the Tags of your API

To make your content well-structured and organized, you can tag content with metadata. For example, if you content is relevant for admins, you can create a tag to cluster information about these roles:

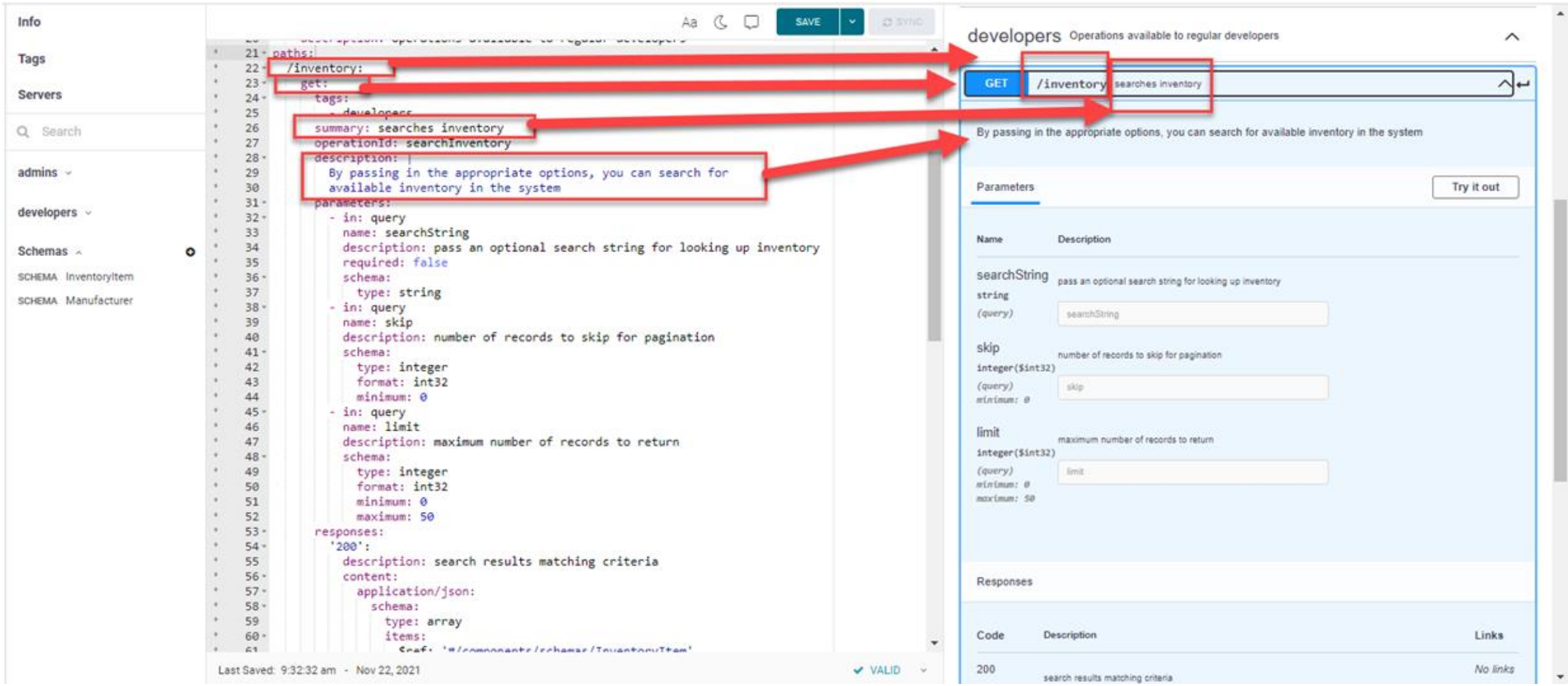


Step 6: Define the API Operations and Paths

1. Define which are the *operations* that your API supported (GET, SET, POST, DELETE, etc.)
2. Define the path (that is, *endpoints*) in the URL that was defined to access this part of the API. (/path)
3. Define the tags (if applicable) to use for this path.
4. Write a short summary and a more detailed description about this part of your API.
5. Describe the API request parameters.
6. Describe the API responses.

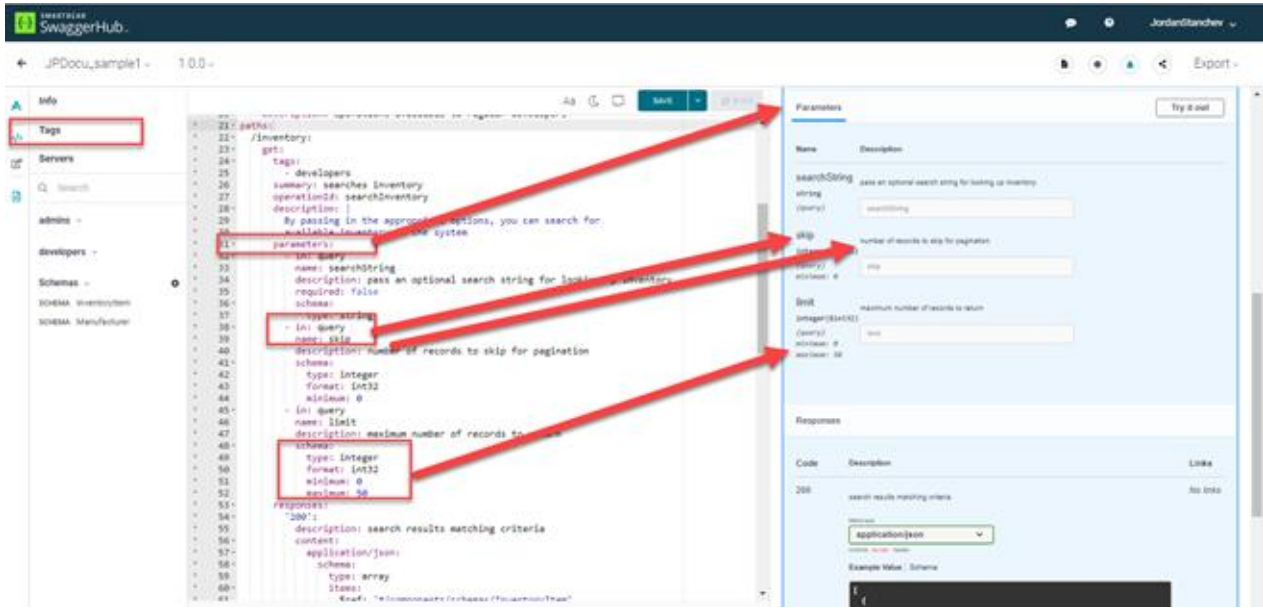


Sample API Operation and Path

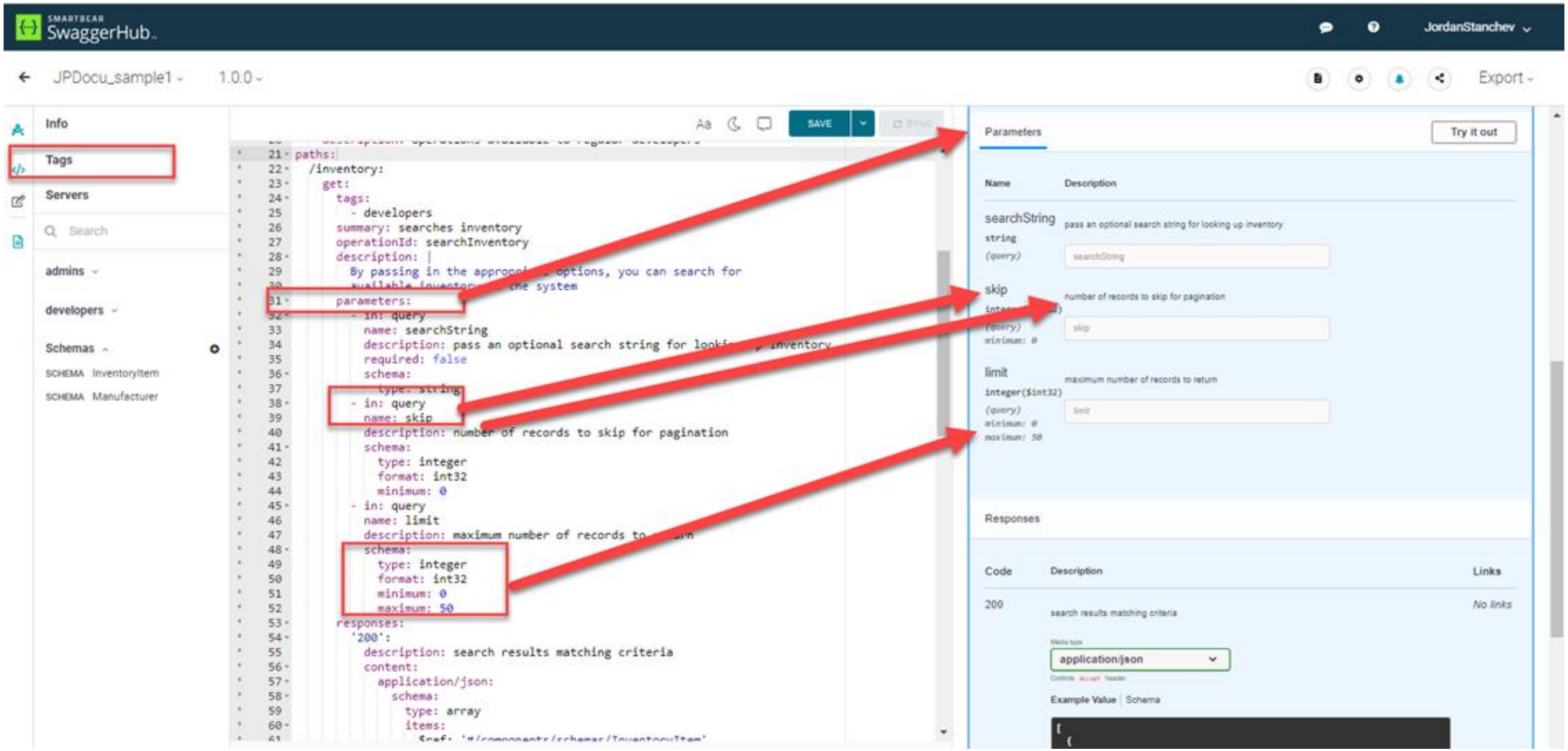


Step 7: Document the API Parameters

1. Define which are the *parameters* of the API requests.
2. Define how the parameter is received.
3. Define the parameter name and its description.
5. Define if the parameter is mandatory (required: true) or optional (required: false).
6. Define additional parameter properties, as required.



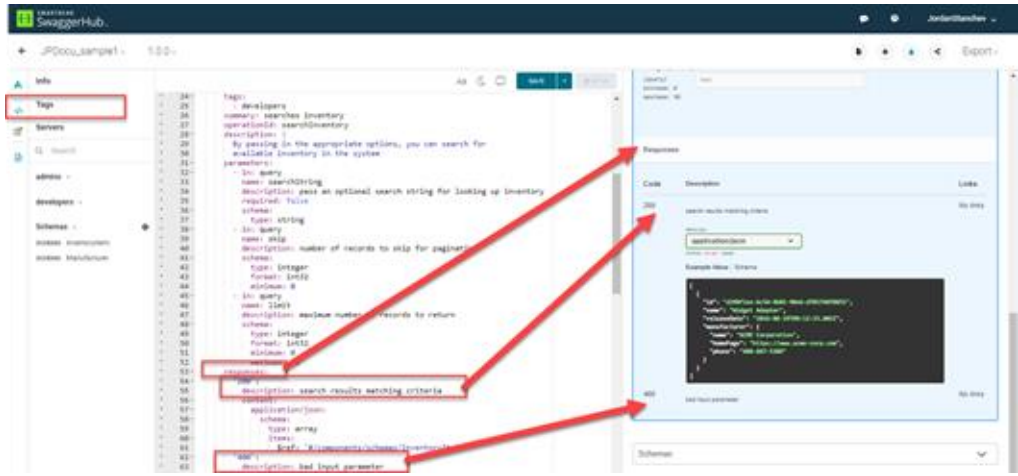
Sample Parameters



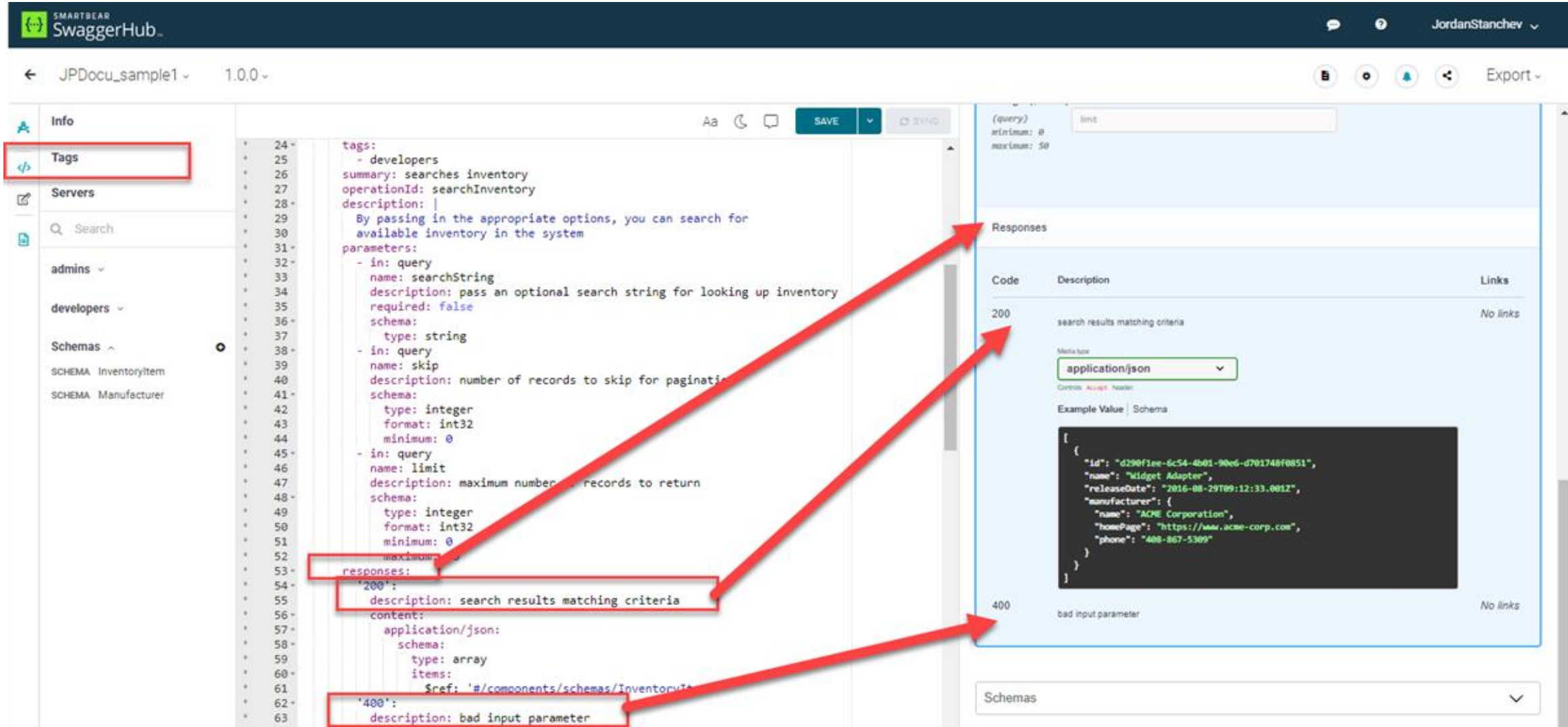
Step 8: Document the API Responses

1. Define which are the responses that your API returns.

2. Define responses codes and error response codes that the API returns.

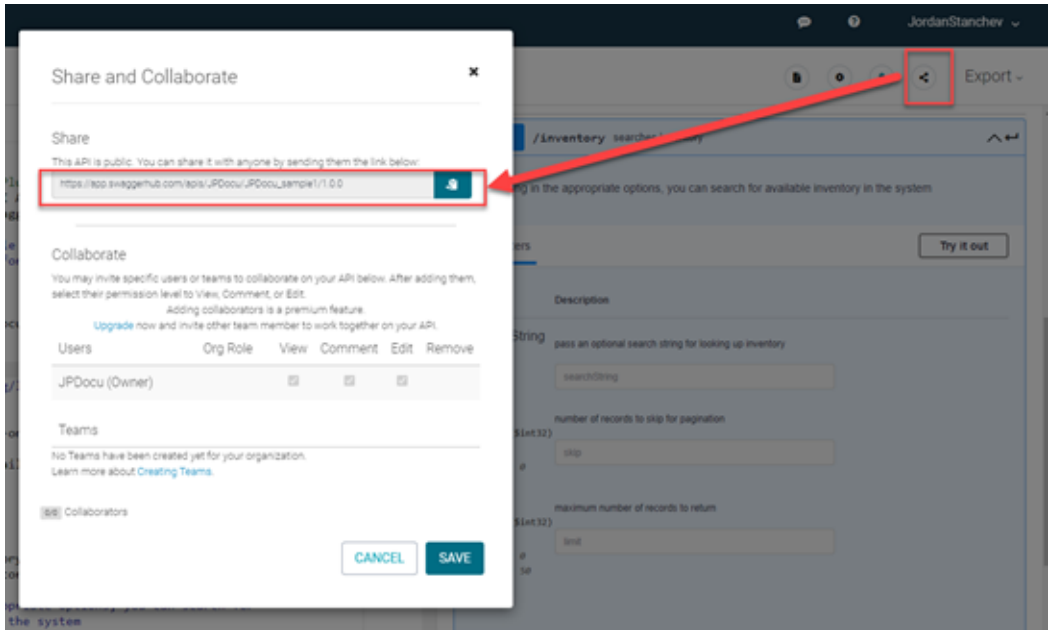


Sample Response

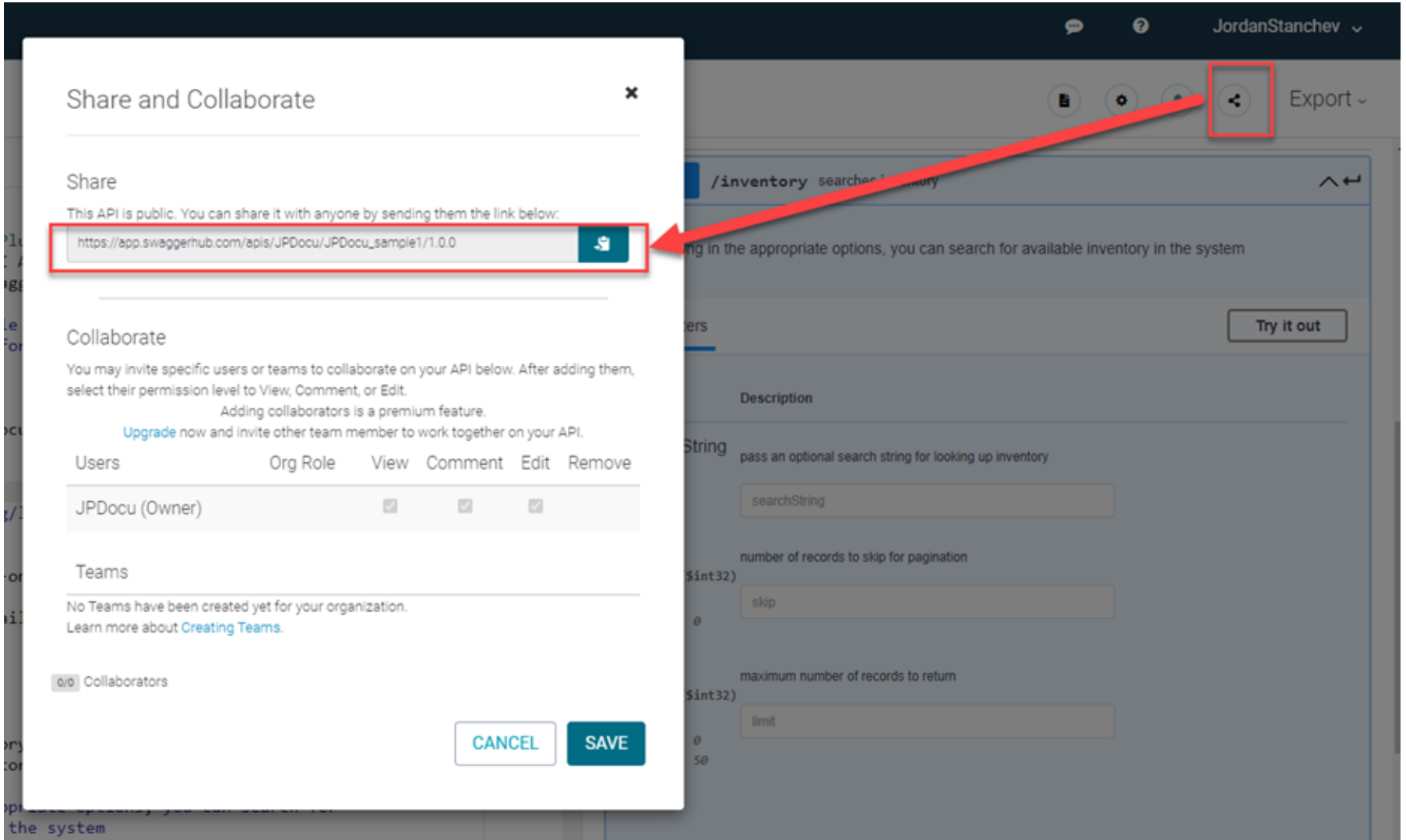


Step 9: Export the API documentation

- Congratulations! You have just finished writing your first API documentation! Let's deliver it to the rest of the world!
- Choose *Share and Collaborate* button.
- This gives you the URL that points to your documentation!



Sample


JordanStanchev
Export
Share and Collaborate
Share
This API is public. You can share it with anyone by sending them the link below:
https://app.swaggerhub.com/apis/JPDocu/JPDocu_sample1/1.0.0
Collaborate
You may invite specific users or teams to collaborate on your API below. After adding them, select their permission level to View, Comment, or Edit.
Adding collaborators is a premium feature.
Upgrade now and invite other team member to work together on your API.
Users
Org Role
View
Comment
Edit
Remove
JPDocu (Owner)
Teams
No Teams have been created yet for your organization.
Learn more about Creating Teams.
0/0 Collaborators
CANCEL
SAVE
/inventory
Try it out
Description
pass an optional search string for looking up inventory
searchString
number of records to skip for pagination
skip
maximum number of records to return
limit

About the Instructor

Jordan Stanchev

- PMP, User Assistance Development Architect at SAP Labs Bulgaria
- Instructor in Technical Communication and Localization Master's Degree Program (University of Strasbourg)
- Instructor on Udemy and Udemy Business
- Co-founder of JPDocu School of Technical Writing
- Co-founder of TEKOM Bulgaria (2015)

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